

Chapter

Red Flowers and Durva — The Secret of the Symbols in Ganapati Worship



Introduction: The Message Hidden in the Offerings

Two things are offered in a special way in the worship of Ganapati — red flowers and durva grass. We usually offer them simply as tradition. Acharya Upendra ji explains that both are deep symbols: the red flower stands for the seeker's effort, and durva for their humility and surrender.

1. Why Red Is Dear to Ganapati

Acharya ji points to the meditation verse of the Ganapati Atharvashirsha, in which Ganapati is described again and again with the word "rakta" (red):

raktaṁ lambodaraṁ śūrpakarṇakaṁ
raktavāsasam |
raktagandhānuliptāṅgaṁ raktapuṣpaiḥ
supūjitam | |

"Red in colour, with a large belly, with ears like
winnowing fans, clad in red garments, his limbs
anointed with red sandalwood paste, and well
worshipped with red flowers."

— Ganapati Atharvashirsha

"He likes that red-coloured flower. ... It says rakta, rakta,
rakta. That means this is rajas shakti."

Rajas, or rajoguna, is the quality that gives action, energy and movement. According to Acharya ji, **the colour red is the symbol of Ganapati's rajas shakti — the energy of action.**

2. The Puranic Story and Its Real Meaning

Acharya ji gives the Puranic story like this:

"After killing the asuras, he smeared their blood all over his body — that is what the Purana says."

But he does not leave the story at its literal meaning:

"But in reality, it means — I should be ready to work with blood and sweat; only then will you become Vinayaka."

Vinayaka is a name of Ganapati — the leader who removes obstacles. Acharya ji's point is that **whoever worships Vinayaka must also be ready to work with full effort.**

3. Do Not Fear the Struggle

When the "asuras" of life — difficulties and obstacles — appear, what should the seeker's attitude be? Acharya ji says:

"To kill the asuras, I will not live in fear."

"If ever I too go into battle, the only question is whether I will win or lose; both heads are going to be broken, both are going to bleed."

"That means some shakti is certainly going to be used. Symbolic of that — rajas shakti."

In any struggle, strength will certainly be spent — that much is sure. The only question is who wins. **The red flower is the symbol of this courage and this use of strength.**

"So all of that is the sadhana of Ganapati. That is why the red flower is symbolic."

4. Durva: Beyond the Threes

Now Acharya ji comes to the second symbol, durva. He recalls the lines of the Ganapati Atharvashirsha:

tvam̐ guṇatrayātītaḥ tvam̐ avasthātrayātītaḥ |
tvam̐ dehatrayātītaḥ tvam̐ kālatrayātītaḥ ||

"You are beyond the three gunas, beyond the three
states, beyond the three bodies and beyond the
three times."

— Ganapati Atharvashirsha

"Durva means, as they say — gunatrayatita,
dehatrayatita, kalatrayatita, avasthatrayatita — so there
are three, three, three things; durva is the symbol of
those three things."

These words mean:

- **Gunatrayatita** — beyond all three gunas: sattva, rajas and tamas
- **Dehatrayatita** — beyond all three bodies: gross, subtle and causal
- **Kalatrayatita** — beyond all three times: past, present and future

- **Avasthatrayatita** — beyond all three states: waking, dreaming and deep sleep

And the feeling with which durva is offered:

"I keep offering them one by one; as many as I can, I am offering."

Offering durva is the symbol of laying all these threes, one by one, at Ganapati's feet.

5. The Tree Breaks, Durva Bends

The second message of durva lies in its nature:

"Durva is like our grass; it is a variety of grass."

"A big tree breaks because of its ego; and this (durva) — it is said that even when the wind comes, it bends."

In a strong wind, the big, stiff tree breaks, but durva bends and survives. **Ego breaks; humility endures.**

"So if that is my state, then the energy matches with Ganapati."

6. The Science of Energy

Acharya ji says there is not only a feeling behind durva but also a reason in energy:

"There is a scientific reason for it too — we call it energy, don't we — if you count an energy level like Ganapati's, then by science this (durva) matches it."

That is, **the energy of durva matches the energy of the Ganapati principle**, which is why it suits his worship.

Summary: Key Teachings

- 1 **The red flower is the symbol of rajas shakti** — the energy of action that is dear to Ganapati.
- 2 The real meaning of the Puranic story of the asuras' blood is **readiness to work with blood and sweat** — "only then will you become Vinayaka."

- 3 Strength will be spent in any struggle; **do not live in fear before obstacles.**
- 4 **Durva is the symbol of going beyond the threes —** gunatrayatita, dehatrayatita, kalatrayatita, avasthatrayatita — which we offer one by one.
- 5 **A big tree breaks from ego; durva bends in the wind** — this humble state is what brings us in tune with Ganapati's energy.
- 6 At the level of energy too, **durva matches the Ganapati principle.**

In Ganapati's worship, red flowers and durva are offered together: one is the resolve of full effort, the other of full humility. May both walk together in the seeker's life too — that is the message of these symbols.